As a college student in India, your digital life is likely centered around UPI payments, Aadhaar-linked services, and academic portals. While these tools make life easier, they also create specific vulnerabilities.

Here is an actionable checklist to help you stay secure in 2026.

Stay Safe Online: The Essential Student Checklist

1. **The Golden Rule of UPI:** Never enter your UPI PIN to **receive** money. Scammers often send "Collect Requests" on apps like GPay or PhonePe, claiming you've won a scholarship or a prize. If a transaction asks for your PIN, money is **leaving** your account.
2. **Avoid QR Code Traps:** Do not scan a QR code sent over WhatsApp or Telegram to "verify" your identity or "receive a payment." Legitimate companies and government portals will never ask you to scan a code to credit your account.
3. **Use Masked Aadhaar:** When providing ID for hostel registrations, exams, or SIM cards, download a **Masked Aadhaar** from the UIDAI portal. This hides the first eight digits of your Aadhaar number, preventing your primary identity key from being harvested by low-security databases.
4. **Lock Your Biometrics:** Use the **mAadhaar app** to "Lock" your biometrics. This prevents anyone from using your fingerprint data for unauthorized Aadhaar-enabled payment systems (AePS) or SIM swaps.
5. **Identify 'Task-Based' Job Scams:** Be skeptical of WhatsApp or Telegram messages offering "Work from Home" or "YouTube Like" tasks. If a job requires you to pay a "security deposit" or "investment fee" to withdraw your earnings, it is a scam.
6. **Secure Your WhatsApp:** Enable **Two-Step Verification** (Settings > Account). This adds a PIN requirement so that even if a scammer tricks you into sharing an OTP, they cannot log into your account on another device.
7. **Audit Public Wi-Fi Use:** Avoid accessing your University LMS or banking apps over free public Wi-Fi in canteens or railway stations. If you must use it, always use a **Virtual Private Network (VPN)** to encrypt your data.
8. **Check the 'Sender' Domain:** Phishing emails often look official but come from slightly misspelled domains (e.g., support@g00gle.com instead of google.com). Always tap the sender's name to see the actual email address before clicking any links.

Emergency Reporting Channels

If you fall victim to financial fraud or cybercrime, every minute counts. Use these official channels immediately:

- **Call 1930:** The National Cyber Crime Helpline. Reporting within the "Golden Hour" (the first 2 hours) is critical for freezing stolen funds.
- **Visit cybercrime.gov.in:** File a formal complaint on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal to initiate a legal investigation.